Act 4 Macbeth Questions

In preparation for the Literature Essay Test next term, answer Questions 1, 3, 4, 8 and 9. Answer in full sentences and use PEEL effectively.

Calm, soothe, ease

1. How do the witches lull Macbeth into a false sense of security?

The witches give Macbeth a series of predictions that make him believe he is almost impossible to defeat. The apparitions tell him that he must "beware Macduff", which confirms that Macduff is a threat but gives Macbeth a warning. They also indicate that "none of woman born / Shall harm Macbeth", which Macbeth interprets as meaning that no human being can kill him. Finally, they tell him he will be safe until "Great Birnam Wood to high Dunsinane Hill / Shall come against him", which seems impossible because a forest cannot literally move. These prophecies make Macbeth overconfident and complacent. Instead of recognising the warnings within the predictions, he focuses on the apparently impossible conditions that seem to guarantee his safety. The witches therefore manipulate Macbeth by telling him partial truths that he interprets incorrectly.

2. Provide the details of each apparition as well as their messages to Macbeth.
3. From your understanding of these apparitions, how are they examples of equivocation? Explain how each is deceptive.

equivocation (noun): the use of ambiguous language to conceal the truth or to avoid committing oneself; prevarication.
"I say this without equivocation."

1. prevarication (noun): the use of ambiguous or evasive language or behaviour to conceal the truth or avoid committing oneself.
"The moment I asked about the marketing set-up, there was a great deal of prevarication."

The apparitions use equivocation because their messages are technically true but deliberately misleading. Macbeth assumes that no one born from a woman can harm him, but Macduff was "from his mother's womb / Untimely ripped." He also believes it is impossible for Birnam Wood to move to Dunsinane, but Malcolm's soldiers later carry branches from the forest towards the castle. The witches therefore give Macbeth partial truths that he misinterprets, creating a false sense of security. The witches exploit Macbeth's tendency to interpret information according to what he wants to believe. Their equivocation is particularly effective because Macbeth is so desperate for reassurance.

4. How are the deaths of Lady Macduff and her son particularly evil? What does this illustrate about the change in Macbeth's character?

   The murders of Lady Macduff and her son are particularly evil because they are innocent and defenceless victims. Neither has participated in any political plot against Macbeth. The young son is especially vulnerable because he is only a child. Macbeth orders the murders simply because he sees Macduff as a threat. This demonstrates how far Macbeth has changed since the beginning of the play. Initially, Macbeth struggles with guilt and questions whether he should murder Duncan. By Act 4, he has become ruthless, impulsive and tyrannical. Significantly, Macbeth now decides to act "before" his thoughts can be considered carefully. He has moved from reluctantly committing one murder to ordering the deaths of an entire family. This illustrates the corrupting effect of Macbeth's pursuit of power. His violence has become increasingly indiscriminate, and he is prepared to murder innocent people to protect his position as king.

5. Account for Malcolm's claims to be an evil tyrant worse than Macbeth when speaking to Macduff.
6. Based on your understand of the play thus far, why are Macduff and the English forces so eager to defeat Macbeth and get him out of power?
7. Discuss the mention of King Edward, the English King, in this act.
8. Lady Macbeth is not involved in Macbeth's murder of Macduff's family. Critically discuss how this sharply contrasts her initial involvement in their quest for power.

   At the beginning of the play, Lady Macbeth is deeply involved in Macbeth's pursuit of power. She questions his masculinity, encourages him to murder Duncan and helps him overcome his hesitation. She is initially more ruthless and determined than Macbeth.

   However, by Act 4, Macbeth is acts independently of Lady Macbeth. He does not consult her before ordering the murder of Macduff's family. This represents a significant reversal in their relationship. Initially, Lady Macbeth encourages Macbeth's violence, but later, Macbeth initiates violence independently.

   This also demonstrates Macbeth's transformation. He no longer needs Lady Macbeth to persuade him to commit evil acts. In fact, he has become more ruthless and violent than she is. At the same time, Lady Macbeth's absence from these later murders contributes to her character development. She has begun to suffer psychologically from her involvement in Duncan's murder, eventually becoming consumed by guilt. Macbeth, meanwhile, appears increasingly emotionally detached from the

consequences of his actions. The contrast, therefore, demonstrates both the breakdown of their relationship and the extent to which Macbeth has become corrupted by his ambition.

9. In your opinion, why do the witches interfere with Macbeth's life? Do you think things may have turned out differently if he had not met them? Discuss.

The witches interfere with Macbeth's life because they seem to enjoy creating confusion, disorder and temptation. They predict Macbeth's future but do not directly force him to commit murder. Instead, they plant ideas in his mind and allow his ambition to influence his choices.

Their first predictions awaken Macbeth's desire for the crown. Once he hears that he may become king, he begins to consider how this could happen. However, Macbeth ultimately chooses his actions himself. The witches do not physically force him to murder Duncan, Banquo or Macduff's family.

It is therefore possible that Macbeth's life could have turned out differently if he had never encountered the witches. Without their predictions, he may not have become so focused on becoming king. However, Macbeth already possesses ambition and a desire for advancement, so Shakespeare leaves open the possibility that he might have pursued power through another route.

The witches can therefore be viewed as catalysts rather than the sole causes of Macbeth's downfall. They introduce the temptation, but Macbeth's own choices, ambition and moral weakness ultimately drive the tragedy.

Shakespeare deliberately creates uncertainty about whether Macbeth is controlled by fate or responsible for his own downfall. This connects to the recurring theme of fate versus free will and makes the witches' role deliberately ambiguous.